



COVER
STORY

By S. PRASANNARAJAN

Many midnights ago, when Jawaharlal Nehru ushered in the freedom of a people from imperial rule in a speech soaked in poetry, he could not have noticed those uninvited guests who lurked beyond the gates of the Constituent Assembly in New Delhi. They were the ghosts of Partition, and trapped in their whispers were the untold stories of loss, separation and savagery. Stories whose first drafts should be traced to the hundreds of resolutions passed by the interlocutors of Independence and their competing rhetoric. Stories that would repudiate the romance of passive resistance that made India a unique item in the glossary of national struggle. Partition was more than a geographical mutilation of the sub-continent; it was one of those dehumanising horror stories that have sustained the 20th century's narratives on revolutions and liberation, be it the Fuhrer's Final Solution or the Pol Pot's ethnic cleansing, Mao's Cultural Revolution or Stalin's Great Terror. It is a stain on our freedom, the scar on our memory as a nation. Or, for the post-Midnight generation, an image in commemorative sepia.

Today, as the country recovers from its 62nd birthday party, our freedom to make history a permanent site of dispute has brought Partition back to the headlines. The provocateur this time is Jaswant Singh, who in his book *Jinnah: India-Partition-Independence* not only challenges the conventional wisdom on the division of India but has committed the blasphemy of demythifying national heroes like Nehru and Sardar Patel: "Jinnah did not so much win Pakistan as the Congress leaders—Nehru and Patel finally conceded Pakistan to Jinnah, with the British acting as an ever helpful midwife." The party banished him: Jaswant tasted the saffron version of Siberia in Shimla. Still, the Sangh Parivar's newest outcast did not break new historical ground with his reappraisal of Quaid-i-Azam; he only refurbished an argument as old as Independence, and so far, it was mostly confined to history books. Now press releases are replacing scholarship and party spokespersons are aspiring to be the arbiters of history. They have only strengthened the nationally soothing stereotypes of good and evil. So the question still remains: Who partitioned India?

Or, more specifically, was Mohammad Ali Jinnahbhai the singular villain of the piece? In those dramatic days in the Forties, the idea of freedom was a backroom thriller in which the main protagonists were Gandhi, Nehru, Patel, Jinnah and Mountbatten. The author of the two-nation theory had already made up his mind: Pakistan was the only viable answer to the aspirations of the Muslims, though the majority of them would not find a place in his Islamic homeland. "Very often," he said in a speech at the Muslim League convention in 1940, "the

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